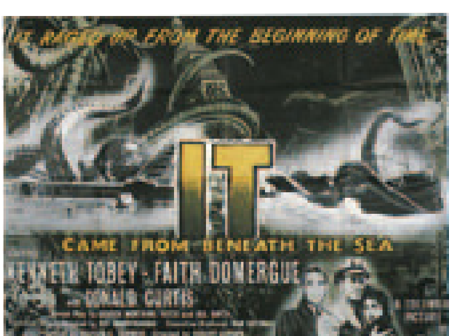
The darkest depths

THERE IS NO LIGHT in the oceans below 3,300 ft (1,000 m), just inky blackness. Many fish in the dark zone are black too, making them almost invisible. Light organs are used as signals to find a mate or to lure prey. Food is scarce in the cold, dark depths. Ultimately, all the animals have to rely on is what little rains down from above. Deep-sea fish make the most of little food by having huge mouths and stretchy stomachs, giving fish a strange appearance. Often they are small or weigh little due to lightweight bones and muscles. Being lightweight helps fish in the dark zone maintain neutral buoyancy (keeping at one level without having to swim), even though most have no gas-filled swim bladders.

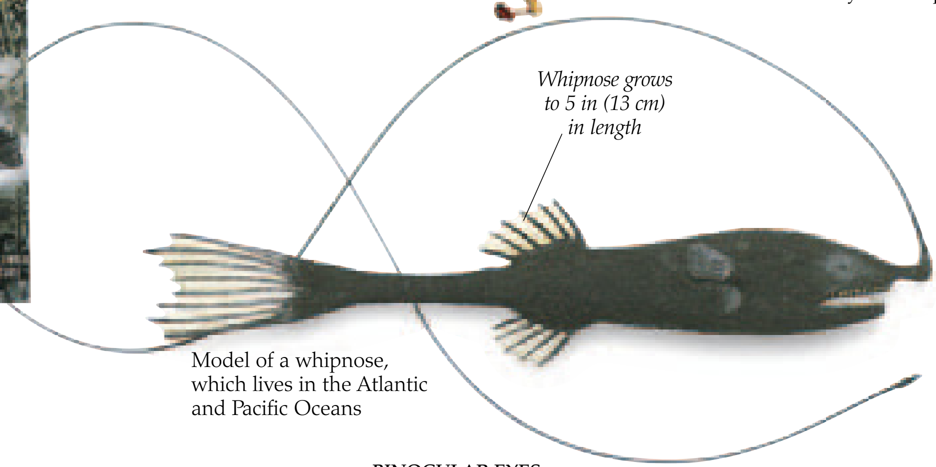
UMBRELLA MOUTH GULPER
With its large mouth opened wide, the gulper eel is always ready to swallow any food, such as shrimp and small fish, it may come across. The gulper probably catches food by swimming along slowly with its mouth open. Adult gulper eels live in the lower part of the twilight zone and in the dark zone. The young stages resemble the leaflike larvae of European eels (pp.38–39) and are found in the sunlit zone from 330–660 ft (100–200 m). As they grow, the young gulper eels descend into deeper water.

Gulper eel lives in the dark depths below temperate and tropical surface waters

FISHING LINE
The whipnose has a long, whiplike lure for attracting passing prey. Prey is drawn toward the lure, thinking it may be a source of food, then gets snapped up by the whipnose.



MONSTER MOVIES
Films about scary monsters are always popular, especially those from the pitch black ocean depths. Curiously, so little of the deep ocean has been explored that there could be strange animals yet to be discovered. But most deep sea animals are small, because there is so little food at these depths.



Model of a whipnose, which lives in the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans

BINOCULAR EYES
Gigantura's extraordinary tubular eyes are probably used to pinpoint the glowing light organs of its prey. Even though *Gigantura* has a narrow body, its skin can stretch so that it can swallow fish larger than itself.